Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics

Data Strategy

Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload — What to connect, why, and how to decide

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> **How This Document Fits**
>
> This is a **Strategy** guide. Read this to decide your data approach. Then hand off to IT with the Data Onboarding Guide for step-by-step implementation.

1. Why Upload Org Data? (Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload)

A common question: *"We already have Department, Manager, and Organisation in Entra ID — why do we need to upload a CSV?"*

Entra ID provides a baseline, but org data uploads unlock significantly more analytics capability:

Capability	Entra ID Only
Department filter on dashboard	Yes (Entra ID “Department” attribute)
Job Function / Job Discipline filter	No
Location filter	No
Level / Seniority filter	No
Custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency, BU, Region)	No
Multi-agency / multi-BU partitioning	Yes — if each agency has a distinct email domain, use the sys
Before/after cohort segmentation in Power BI	No segmentation
Manager hierarchy accuracy	Depends on Entra ID completeness
Data freshness control	Updated by directory team (often delayed)

TIP: When Entra ID Alone Is Sufficient

If you **only** need the Copilot Dashboard with tenant-level views and Department filtering — and the Entra ID Department attribute is accurate and consistently populated — you can skip the org data upload. However, if you need **any** of the following, org data upload is required: Location or Job Function filters, custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency), or before/after cohort analysis in Power BI.

2. What Breaks with an Incomplete Entra ID Hierarchy?

If the Entra ID `Manager` attribute is missing or inconsistent for many users:

Feature	Impact
Auto CxO Identification	Fewer leaders are auto-identified. Users without a clear reporting line
Manager Settings (team-level data)	Managers without a populated `Manager` attribute or without enough
Filter by manager hierarchy (Publish Reports)	Published reports with “Filter by manager hierarchy” will show incom
Advanced Analytics cohort segmentation	Manager-based grouping will be inaccurate.

Recommendation: If more than 20% of users lack a Manager attribute, prioritise fixing directory data or supplement with an org data CSV upload that includes correct `ManagerId` values.

3. The Data Source Change Warning

Once org data is uploaded, it **replaces Entra ID as the data source** for the uploaded attributes in dashboard filters:

- Department values come from the CSV, not from Entra ID — even if they differ
- If you stop uploading, the data becomes stale (not reverted to Entra ID)
- **Reversal is now self-service:** You can use **parallel data ingestion** to keep Entra as the source for `ManagerId` and `Organization` while adding custom attributes via CSV. To stop using uploaded data entirely, clear the Entra connection selections or use the “Replace All data” option with a single dummy row. See Microsoft Learn.
- **Before uploading:** Confirm readiness to own the ongoing refresh cycle (monthly re-uploads recommended)

4. Choose Your Upload Method

Start with *"What HRIS do you use?"* — not *"how do I upload a CSV."*

Method	Who Manages	Status	Best For
SAP SuccessFactors Connector	Global Admin + SAP SF Admin	GA	Organisations u
Workday Connector	Global Admin + Workday Admin	GA	Organisations u
Azure Blob Storage	Global Admin + Data Engineer	GA	Automated CSV
API-Based Import	Global Admin + Developer	Preview	Programmatic p
CSV Upload — M365 Admin Center	Org Data Source Administrator	GA	Universal fallba
CSV Upload — Viva Insights	Insights Administrator	Deprecated (mid-2026)	Legacy path. U

NOTE: Decision Logic

- **Use SAP SuccessFactors or Workday** if your org runs either HRIS — eliminates manual CSV entirely
- **Use Azure Blob Storage** if you want automated CSV drops from a data warehouse
- **Use API-based import** if you need incremental refresh or have a custom HRIS
- **Use CSV upload** for everything else — universal compatibility

TIP: Bypass On-Premises AD

If your HRIS data flows through **SAP SuccessFactors → middleware → on-premises AD → Entra ID**, be aware that Viva Insights only picks up 3 attributes from Entra (PersonId, ManagerId, Organization). Custom fields in Entra `extensionAttributes` are **not synced**.

Solution: Use the HRIS connector to send data directly to M365 — bypassing AD entirely for analytics purposes.

5. Data Planning Worksheet

Complete this before any upload. Share answers with your IT team when you hand off to the Data Onboarding Guide.

#	Question
1	Which HRIS does your organisation use? (SAP SF, Workday, Oracle, Custom, None)
2	Can your HRIS export a CSV with employee email, manager email, and department?
3	Which dashboard filters do you need beyond Department? (Job Function, Location, Level, Cost Centre, Agency, F
4	Do you need custom attributes for segmentation in Power BI reports? (e.g., Copilot Pilot Group, Hire Date, BU)
5	Who will own the monthly data refresh? (HR, IT, Data Engineering)
6	Is your tenant migrated to "Organizational Data in Microsoft 365" in M365 Admin Center?
7	Do multiple agencies share a single email domain? (If yes, you'll need a custom `Agency` attribute for partitioning
8	Do you need to share org data with apps beyond Viva Insights? (M365 Profile, People Skills)

6. Organizational Data Upload Migration

> **IMPORTANT: April 2026 Migration**
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> Microsoft is migrating all tenants from the Viva Insights web app to the **M365 Admin Center** as the single upload point. By mid-2026, all tenants will be migrated.
>
> - New platform: **Organizational Data in Microsoft 365** at `admin.microsoft.com` → Setup → Migration and imports
> - New role: **Organizational Data Source Administrator** manages uploads
> - Supports HRIS connectors, Azure Blob, API-based import — not just CSV
> - Data serves multiple M365 apps (Copilot Dashboard, Viva Insights, M365 User Profile)

Which path am I on?

1. Go to `admin.microsoft.com` → Setup → Migration and imports
2. If you see **"Organizational Data in Microsoft 365"** → you're migrated → follow the M365 Admin Center path in the Data Onboarding Guide
3. If you don't see it → you're pre-migration → follow the Viva Insights legacy path
4. If unsure → check Message Center for migration notifications

7. What to Read Next

Ready to...	Read this
Upload data (step-by-step)	Data Onboarding Guide (Setup layer)
See the full attribute mapping table	Attribute Reference (Reference layer)
Troubleshoot a failed upload	Troubleshooting Guide (Reference layer)
Understand multi-agency data isolation	Multi-Agency Decision Guide (Strategy layer)

> **Disclaimer**
>
> This guide is provided as a procedural reference. Always refer to Organizational Data in Microsoft 365 on Microsoft Learn for the most up-to-date information.